

Divine Proposition

Bowing to the demands of non-Muslim minorities, the state sets up a financial corporation to fund Christians' pilgrimage to Bethlehem



It's a call that the Andhra Pradesh Government has finally honoured. A pilgrimage to the Holy Land of Bethlehem has been made easy for the Christians in the state. State Minority Welfare Minister Mohammed Ali Shabbir says, "An exclusive financial corporation will fund and arrange the Christians' visit to the holy shrines. It's on the lines of the arrangements made for Muslims going on the Haj pilgrimage to Mecca."

For this purpose, five Christian religious places have been identified with Jerusalem as the principal stopover. The week-long pilgrimage will have at least 50-100 pilgrims. With a budget of Rs 2 crore, about 900 poor Christians can expect to visit the Holy Land this financial year. In fact, the first batch of pilgrims is likely to visit Bethlehem in August. The Government is giving a grant of Rs 20,000 for each pilgrim, an amount given to Haj pilgrims as well.

COUNT YOUR BLESSINGS: Reddy (right) blessed by pastors

While a date with the divinity has almost been fixed, a certification issued by the mandal revenue officer or tehsildar will identify the eligible pilgrims. The applicant's secondary school certificate is yet another tool through which the eligibility will be judged. The pilgrims are to be chosen on the first-come-first-serve basis. They can apply online and must have a passport valid for two years. To smoothen the process, the state Government has decided to create an exclusive division headed by an IAS officer of the rank of principal secretary in the Department of Minority Welfare. There's also a possibility of creation of a new department for the welfare of Christian minorities supervised by the civil servant heading the Department of Minority Welfare.

It may sound too good to be true,

but the new entity will not just look at the religious concerns of the Christians but will also take up issues like mass marriages. Couples who marry under this scheme will be given Rs 15,000 to meet the expenses. Keeping pace with these developments, a similar scheme for Muslims will be taken up by the Wakf Board. Generosity is reigning, with Chief Minister Y.S. Rajasekhara Reddy allocating Rs 5 crore for the project.

The mantra seems to be simple—make hay while the state Government shines on you. These measures are being taken at a time when numerous complaints pour in from the non-Muslim minorities who state that the Muslims are enjoying benefits under the Department of Minority Welfare while the rest are denied their share of funds proportionate to their population. Hence, Reddy decided to end the discrimination. The funds for different welfare schemes will be allocated in accordance with the population of the minorities. According to the 2001 Census, Christians account for about 1.55 per cent of Andhra Pradesh's population (about 12 lakh), while Muslims form 9.2 per cent of the population (about 70 lakh). There are about 31,000 Sikhs and an equal number of other minorities.

However, the move hasn't been given a clean chit by all the members of the community. Archbishop Marampudi Joji, head of the Hyderabad Diocese that represents the Catholic Church in Andhra Pradesh, says, "This is a welcome gesture but the Government needs to rework the norms for the pilgrims, especially where they have to prove that they are poor or even Christians by presenting certificates given by the authorities. This could sadly lead to spiritual groupism." On the other hand, G. Samuel, president of the state chapter of the All India Christian Council, says, "A separate finance corporation would ensure equitable distribution of Rs 127 crore allocated for the welfare of minorities."

Sociologists contend that demand-driven strategy may lead to sharper divides. But then with elections fast approaching, political expediency may take precedence over political reasoning.

by Amarnath K. Menon



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